moonlighting

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at https://archiveofourown.org/works/89212671.

Rating:
Teen And Up Audiences

Archive Warning:
No Archive Warnings Apply

Categories:
F/F, Multi

Fandom:
KPop Demon Hunters (2025)

Relationship:
Mira/Rumi/Zoey (KPop Demon Hunters)

Characters:
Rumi (KPop Demon Hunters), Mira (KPop Demon Hunters), Zoey (KPop Demon Hunters), Jinu (KPop Demon Hunters)

Additional Tags:
Celine's also in this but not really enough to warrant a tag, Fluff, Romantic Comedy, Alternate Universe - No Powers, Secret Identity, Identity Reveal, Alternate Universe - College/University, only on a very technical level though because it is ACTUALLY a butler cafe au in disguise, just like rumi!, rumi: I CAN'T LET THEM KNOW I WORK AT A BUTLER CAFE, jinu: yes their weekly visits here mean they would be very bothered to learn this about you naturally, very very fluffy and silly, MASSIVE shoutout to Whimsy who both came up with this concept in the first place and drew the FANTASTIC cover art inside!, an absolute honor to collab with you Whimsy!!

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Polytrix Reverse Big Bang (July 2026)

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by arendellesfirstwinter

Summary

Double-checking her golden contact lenses in the mirror, Rumi fluffs out her hair~~lo~~ng and loose from its braid~~so~~ that it flows in waves behind her, a vision of violet cascading down the black velvet of her suit jacket. She tugs on her signature white butler gloves, straightens her lavender tie, and steps out of the back and onto the floor itself.

The bell dings, a signal for new cafe guests arriving in the waiting room.

Perfect timing.

Rumi grins sharply, schooling her features into classy neutrality, then glances through the window of the door to the waiting area, sees two freshly familiar women, and *yelps*.

Or: Rumi's balancing life as a university student by day and themed cafe butler by night when the fall semester starts, where she q~~i~~ickly finds herself partnering with two classmates~~Z~~oey and Mira~~f~~or a group project. They're friendly and sweet, but there's just one small problem: they've taken to freqenting the exact cafe where Rumi works and unknowingly reqesting her butler persona, Artemis, *every single visit*.

Notes

Hi hello!! So excited to finally share this!! I've been working together a while now in a collaboration with the *incredible* Whimsy (doodlesofwhimsy on tumblr and DragonWhimsical on

twitter) and this fic concept is all hers! She came up with the very initial idea of Rumi working secretly at a butler cafe, and it's been such a blast to put it all together into a fic while she created the fantastic cover art you'll see below! Whimsy, I hope I've done this justice, and you've been a phenomenal partner <3

Quick shoutout as well to the fantastic gohandinhand for betaing this beast of a fic for me!!

See the end of the work for more notes

▶ Collaboration Cover Art 🎨

"The moon watches over us," Mi-Yeong whispers, holding a tiny giggling Rumi close as she follows her mother's pointing finger to stare upwards in awe, up up up to the night sky above and the beautiful moon nestled within it. "Always has."

Growing up, Rumi's favorite holiday was Chuseok. She remembers distinctly the feeling of gathering beneath the full moon, first with her mother, Mi-Yeong, and then with Celine, and welcoming it as it rose high into the sky.

The moon is wise, and hopeful, and longing, and Celine would whisper to a young Rumi to make a wish.

Rumi often cheated. She had *many* things to wish for, after all, and they varied from good grades to getting dalgona after a long day at the park to wishing the one boy who called her a mean name in class would stub his toe.

Sometimes, she'd wish for friends. (When she meets a rather annoying boy named Jinu in high school, she finally gets part of said wish fulfilled.)

Over the years, she's moved past many of those wishes, but some—like making Celine proud—have stayed the same.

At the end of Dalmaji, the act of welcoming the moon during Chuseok, Rumi always makes sure to thank it. For being there, for being bright and full, and for representing everything she's wanted and everything she's missed.

Beneath the embrace of its light, above all else, Rumi looks to the sky and sees her mother. (The moon's watched over Rumi for as long as she can remember, after all.)

Rumi sees a lot more than her mother in the moon now, though, after years of growing up with changing interests and desires. She thinks of Western folklore about wolves, about star charts and rockets and moon phases that she's rather certain dont mean anything at all, and about the moon's importance in the world's mythology.

One of her favorite stories about the moon relates to—

"Artemis."

goddess of the moon in Greek mythology. Not at first that was Selene but of course it makes sense that over time, a figure as elegant and revered as—

"Artemis."

would become synonymous with something as stable and forthright as the moon. She's a protector of those around her and, above all else, a *hater*, someone who seeks balance, who acts with firm care, who guides those near and—

"*Ri*"

Jolting, Rumi blinks rapidly. She stares at Jinu and shakes her head.

The weight of what he called her finally registers. Frowning, Rumi hisses, "You're not supposed to call me that here!"

Jinu snaps his fingers he has gloves on, so it's less a snap and more a weird muffled rubbing sound in front of her face, exasperated. "Hello? Earth to *Aeis*, but you werent exactly responding to anything else. What, were you lost in space?"

"No! I just—"

"Apollo. Artemis." The clipped voice of Celine, Rumi's guardian, snaps both Rumi and Jinu to attention.

Both of them straighten their postures rigidly and bow, clasping white gloved hands in front of themselves and holding their heads low as Celine sighs.

From this angle, all Rumi can see is Celine's polished Oxford dress shoes and crisp, pressed black trousers, but it serves enough of a reminder that Rumi has a job to do, expectations to fulfill, guests to serve, and Celine to make proud.

Admittedly, Rumi didn't expect when she was growing up that she'd be making Celine proud by moonlighting as a butler in a moon-and-manor themed cafe on her evenings after college classes, but that's neither here nor there.

The silence stretches a moment longer before Celine softens and says, "Straighten back up and take fifteen. The next two sets of guests that walk through that door after time's up are yours."

Rumi and Jinu straighten. Adjusting her collar, Rumi idly combs her fingers through her long, loose hair and dips her head one more time for good measure. "Thank you, Celine," she responds, formal and polite.

Chuffing, Celine taps her index finger to the bottom of Rumi's chin and lightly lifts her head. "Enough of that," she scolds without any bite. "You need to *focus*, but don't think I've forgotten your new semester starts tomorrow. Finish the shift strong, then let's go out together for japchae to celebrate. Does that sound good?"

"Yes, Celine." Rumi smiles, a warmth spreading through her chest the way it always does at the promise of rare time spent with the woman who raised her. Running a small business like the Honmoonlight Cafe isn't easy, and requires longer hours than one would ever expect, so Rumi loves when Celine sets that aside when she's able to and chooses an evening dedicated to just them.

Celine nods once more, then steps out of the back area and into the cafe proper. Her shoes clack on the herringbone hardwood flooring,

accompanied perfectly by the ring of the bell above the door to signal new guests.

As Rumi and Jinu duck into a small sitting room for breaks, the kitchen down one hallway and the cafe down the other, the sound of embarrassed babbling from a couple of younger men flustered at Celine echoes down the hall.

"So," Jinu begins, stretching as carefully as he can without rumpling his suit jacket. The gold silk of his bowtie shimmers faintly with the movement. "Semester tomorrow? No *wonder* you were zoned out."

Sitting hard on one of the plush benches in the room, Rumi drops her head in her hands. "I guess," she mutters a little despairingly. "It's just there's going to be a lot to do this semester, and I know one of tomorrow's classes in particular, Biochemistry, is supposed to be *hell* according to those who've already taken it. I can't afford to let anything slip this semester, Jinu, it's too important."

"Do you really think you will?" He sounds doubtful, which Rumi thinks is supposed to be reassuring, but only serves to reiterate to her that he doesn't understand the weight of the pressure.

"I might! I really, really want this, but if I don't ace this class, I won't be able to get into the Department of Medicine, and it's already been hard enough balancing work here and classes the *past* few semesters."

"Why not take a break?" asks Jinu quietly. "I think Celine would understand."

Rumi shakes her head. "It doesn't matter if she understands or not. She needs me here—you *know* I'm the most popular butler"—

"For *now*."

Ignoring Jinu's interruption, she continues, "and besides, I *like* it. It's fun." She stares at her hands, flexing them open and closed.

"It's nice, you know? There's so much pressure to perform, but it's like I know exactly what I need to do. How I'm supposed to be and act. Everywhere else, and *especially* in my classes, there's no script. I'm just *me*."

Tilting his head, Jinu squints his eyes a moment before leaning forward and poking Rumi in the forehead. "And is that *really* so bad?"

Rumi swats his hand away. "It's just *easier*. I *like* the performing! Oh, and speaking of time's up. Ready to get back out there, Apollo?"

A faint ticking from an old grandfather clock is briefly drowned out as Jinu smirks and says, "As ready as you are, Artemis. Let's show exactly why we're the most popular."

With one last check over their suits, ensuring that they're crisp and sharp, Rumi takes a deep breath, holds her head up high, and steps out into the cafe proper, Jinu at her side.

Coinciding with their exit, they hear the small chime that signals new guests arriving in the opening walkway that functions as a small waiting area. Rumi and Jinu share a quick nod, then move in tandem, crossing the open space to the large, ornate wooden door that marks the official entrance to the cafe.

Jinu, spine straight and hair slicked back, puts on a dazzling smile and turns the knob, holding the door wide open and bowing.

Rumi folds her own gloved hands in front of her and bows as well. "Welcome home," she greets, voice smooth and confident and sharp eyes quickly noting that the guests in front of her are three middle-aged women; she mentally adjusts her form of address accordingly. "My lovely ajumeoni, please come inside."

The three older women titter excitedly, stepping onto the plush, red velvet carpet of the entryway and staring at the interior's beige-painted walls. Intricate gilding along the corners and edges frame various paintings and other assorted decorations made to mimic the

feel of an old, English-style manor, but with uniqely Korean flairs—the sword mounted as a wall centerpiece, for example, is a saingeom, its blade decorated with engraved constellations like Orion and the Ursas Major and Minor that mirror within the embroidered indigo lapel of Rumi's jacket.

Offering a pristinely white gloved hand out, Rumi asks, "May I take your bags?"

Two of the women offer their bags with a smile, a little in awe, while the third hesitates. "It' s a little heavy,"she says, holding the backpack in front of her chest.

Rumi angles her head. "All the more reason for me to carry it for you, my lady."

A faint blush stripes across the bridge of the woman's nose as she holds her bag out and whispers loudly to the other two, "How charming!"

Rumi fights the urge not to visibly preen, instead passing one of the bags to Jinu as he shuts the door carefully behind them. "Allow me to show you to your table. This way, please."She gestures, then spins sharply on her heel, leading them into the open space of the cafe. It's lit by opulent chandeliers and decorated like the dining room of a European lord with chairs of mahogany and silk set in perfect alignment to rosewood tables.

"My name,"Rumi says, pulling out the chairs to the guests, "is Artemis."

"And I am Apollo,"Jinu introduces, bowing once more. "Excuse me, but I've brought your menus. Might I recommend one of our tea sets?"

And so the interaction goes, filled with polite smiles and banter, Rumi and Jinu each eqally competing to be as charming and attentive as possible, much to the older women's surprise and delight.

As other guests trickle in throughout the afternoon, the process repeats, and Rumi finds herself quickly lost within the role, the innate familiarity setting her mind at ease, relaxing her nerves about tomorrow's classes and prioritizing what she knows and enjoys.

And she *enjoys* this, truly. Here, she can play a part, be confident and well-liked and smooth;she loves it.

In the blink of an eye, it's over, and she, Jinu, Celine, and a couple of other regular butlers~~to~~day featured Romance and Mystery~~s~~et to work closing up the shop, helping Bobby, the chef, clean up the kitchen, and head out.

Just like she promised, Celine takes Rumi out to a celebratory dinner of japchae plus some bonus songpyeon~~the~~ half-moon rice cakes are always a special treat~~for~~ dessert, and Rumi once again shoves her nerves for tomorrow to the side to revel in the rare opportunity to spend time outside of work, *relaxing* , with her guardian.

Outside, the moon is as full and bright as Rumi's smile.

Pulling her hood tighter over her mass of hair~~c~~urrently braided for convenience but hidden anyway due to its conspicuous purple dye job~~R~~umi adjusts her face mask and ducks her head as she enters the lecture hall, beelining straight for an empty seat in the back corner.

Class isnt due to start for another fifteen minutes, which absolutely makes her part of the earlier crowd, but Rumi didnt want to risk being late on her very first day (and also maybe wanted the freedom to choose her seat exactly where she did).

She sets her bag down and slips her laptop free, setting it on the long desk that runs the length of the row and popping the lid open. She pulls up her notes app, then the professor's syllabus and online course setup, and waits, idly reading through what's already been

posted before resorting to nervously twirling an old ballpoint pen from her bag that she doesnt *actually* need right now.

As the minutes tick, the seats of the lecture hall begin to fill up, though thankfully the two next to her remain empty.

Finally, the minute hand of the clock next to the board strikes the top of the hour and the professor walks in right on time, with two other girls hot on her heels. The two girls nearly trip over themselves as they bundle behind her, then race up the steps of the hall towards the two remaining seats, right next to—

Ah, yeah, Rumi should've expected that.

The taller one, with long pink hair and piercing eyes, sits one seat over, while the shorter, a girl with a garish yellow bucket hat who's giggling nervously, slides in next to Rumi.

Rumi gives an awkward nod as the shorter girl whispers a greeting, then points towards the front. The shorter girl's head bobs in rapid agreement and she snaps her attention to the professor.

As tough a class as Rumi's anticipating Biochemistry to be, this first one is relatively standard. A brief introduction of the professor, what they're going to learn about throughout the fall semester , a breakdown of the next few weeks, and a heads-up that groups will be formed next class for the semester's final projects.

Throughout, Rumi does her best to focus~~wh~~ich is quite good, on a normal day~~bu~~t finds herself struggling instead. The girl in the bucket hat next to her keeps moving and fidgeting, and it's not like Rumi doesnt *get* it (she's full of pent-up energy more often than not herself) but right now it's just *distrating* .

The girl taps her pen on the side of the desk, *tptptptptptp* , then gets bored of that and rustles around in her bag for something that she presumably doesnt find, then leans back in her chair and readjusts her position, then readjusts again, and again, and again.

She spends most of the lecture—when she's not fidgeting—scratching onto her paper instead with her pen; at first, Rumi had assumed she'd finally quieted down to take notes, but it's an assumption quickly proven wrong with a glance confirming that the page is covered with scratchy doodles of K-pop idols in lieu of a singular written word.

The pink-haired girl is nearly the opposite, sitting almost scarily still the entire time, but, judging by the phone in her hand and the social media being scrolled through upon its screen, was no more focused. (Still, Rumi knows which of the two she'd have preferred sit next to her.)

Finally, the lecture ends and class is dismissed. Rumi begins to pack her laptop up, carefully zipping it inside a purple galaxy-themed case covered in celestial bodies, when the girl with the bucket hat chirps, "Hi! Looks like we'll be in class together! I'm Zoey!"

She sticks her hand out, and Rumi stares a beat.

That's oddly American, but she supposes there *are* plenty of international students here. Rumi takes the hand, bowing a little too out of habit, and says, "I'm Rumi."

Zoey beams, seeming far more delighted to learn this information than Rumi would've ever expected. Her smile is *vibrant*, like a pocketed sun, and a dimple forms in her left cheek as she pumps their hands together a beat for pulling back.

Okay well, she does hope Zoey learns to sit still a little bit better, but maybe she might not be so bad a seat neighbor to have.

Behind Zoey, a throat clears. The girl with pink hair has positioned herself behind Zoey's right shoulder, narrowing her eyes and casually raising an eyebrow expectantly.

Is she waiting on something?

Rumi wracks her brain a moment, then stammers out a quick, "Oh, and um, what's *your* name?"

"Mira." She shrugs, long arms swaying at her side. There's a grace in her movements, like there's energy in Zoey's, and for a brief second, Rumi thinks that both of them would look *so* good in one of Honmoonlight Cafe's butler uniforms.

Oh, nope, Rumi's banishing *that* thought. She is *not* about to start picturing the first two friendly faces of this semester in *suits*— that's just asking for trouble.

"It's nice to meet you both," Rumi replies stiffly, giving a quick bow.

Zoey and Mira do the same. "I look forward to seeing you around!" Zoey says cheerfully, rocking back and forth on her heels as Mira leans over to start packing up her own array of school necessities into her backpack.

Awkwardly, Rumi tries not to swallow her tongue and instead nods. "Yep, sounds good! Have a good day!" She dips her head and turns to leave.

On the way out, she hears the two begin to chatter about afternoon plans—something about a cafe—but it quickly fades into the typical college shuffle.

The minute Rumi puts on her uniform to become Artemis, her exhaustion from the long day's worth of classes melts away. It's not necessarily that this is something Rumi wants to make her career, but as always, it's comforting and familiar, a role to play that she understands.

Here, she can slip on a mask and meet expectations that are easy and simple. Playing a butler is, perhaps, not for everyone—*certainly* not for everyone, Rumi thinks wryly as she catches Abby across the

cafe floor clip his hip on a table and narrowly avoid faceplanting—but, for better or worse, slipping on this persona is second nature. Rumi excels at it;she knows this, Celine knows this, the other butlers know it, and so do the customers.

She also knows, as prideful a thought as it may be, there's a *reason* Artemis is the top requested butler . (Jinu does too, and to his credit, he's come the closest in his Apollo persona to dethroning Rumi, but he's going to have to keep trying a while yet.)

Double-checking her golden contact lenses in the mirror, Rumi fluffs out her hair~~long~~ and loose from its braid~~so~~ that it flows in waves behind her, a vision of violet cascading down the black velvet of her suit jacket. She tugs on her signature white butler gloves, straightens her lavender tie, and steps out of the back and onto the floor itself.

The bell dings, a signal for new cafe guests arriving in the waiting room.

Perfect timing.

Rumi grins sharply, schooling her features into classy neutrality, then glances through the window of the door to the waiting area, sees two freshly familiar women, and *yelps.*

Spinning on her heel, she bolts for the nearest counter, ducking behind it entirely.

Is her face red?

Oh god, it has to be.

Why are *they* here?

How could this happen to her?

What—

"~~are~~ you doing?"

Rumi owlishly blinks up from her hiding spot at Jinu, who's decked out in his Apollo uniform with his sun-colored dress shirt peeking out the top of the jacket and staring back at her.

What is she doing?...

Hiding.

Panicking.

"Taking a break."

"You literally just started your shift," Jinu deadpans.

Rumi pouts up at him, crossing her arms and curling even further inwards.

"Oh my god, are you a child? What is happening? What has pre-med done to you? Do I need to get Cel—"

"No!" hisses Rumi, snaking a hand out to grab Jinu's ankle.

He jumps nearly a foot in the air with a squeal. "Would you—don't do that?! Let me go!"

"Look," Rumi says, her grip tightening, "do *not* tell Celine. Just go serve those two girls who came in, okay?"

Jinu leans against the counter, narrowing his eyes. "Why? They are *literally* your type, normally you are all over those tables. What's so different about—"

"*They're in my Biochem class!*" Rumi bursts out in a harsh whisper.

Jinu's face begins to contort.

"Look," continues Rumi, "the class just started *today*. They *stare* at me, which means that it is *statistically likely* that they'll sit there

again, you know how college students are! I cannot survive an *entire semester* with two classmates knowing *this* is what I do!"

"I really don't think it's that big a deal—"

"Just take them please!"

Heaving a sigh, Jinu says, "Fine, I suppose I—" He pauses, head glancing away as the bell chimes again. When he turns back to Rumi, there's a devilish grin on his face that has her heart sinking instantly.

"Jinu—"

"Sorry, *Artemis*, but *Apollo's* favorite ajummas have just appeared, and you *know* they won't take anyone but me. Abby and Mystery have already got their own tables, so I suppose that makes you it!" He shakes his ankle loose from Rumi's hold and darts out, politely greeting both the group of older women and Zoey and Mira, who he promises will have a host very shortly.

Okay.

No, this is fine.

Rumi can do this.

This is why she dresses so nondescript in classes and hides her hair and wears a mask, to keep a low profile! There's no way they'll recognize her. She just has to go out there and *do her job*.

Artemis.

Confident, calm, smooth.

Quickly combing her hair with her fingers, she shakes it lightly, long purple waves falling across the nape of her neck and down her back, then stands and breathes in deeply. Striding towards the entryway, Rumi approaches Zoey and Mira and bows. One arm tucks up under

her chest while the other wraps behind her back, and she greets, "Good afternoon! Welcome home, agassi. Please, come inside."

Zoey and Mira, dressed exactly as they were in class earlier today, give two stiff bows in return, hands at their sides in a more classically Korean fashion. "Thank you!" Zoey says cheerfully, a wide smile stretching her cheeks.

"May I take your bags?" Rumi holds out her hand.

"No, we're good—"

"Yes, of course!" Zoey snatches Mira's bag and hands it over, hissing something under her breath about "she's being polite! let her do her job!" and placing the bag's strap in Rumi's waiting palm.

Rumi closes her fingers around it firmly, doing her best to keep her facade even as she panics internally.

This is fine. It's working. They dont suspect her. There's noooo issue here.

"Right this way, my ladies." Rumi holds the door open for them, then leads them properly inside to an awaiting empty booth in a back corner. The cushioned seats are a brocaded gold and indigo and bounce as Zoey flops onto one side while Mira slides into the seat across from her.

Zoey tilts her head, peering at Rumi and parting her lips in slight awe. "Whoa, are your eyes golden?"

Clearing her throat, Rumi nods her answer, then holds out two slim binders. "Your menus. Take your time, although I do recommend the tea sets."

"Do you have a favorite?" Mira asks, poring over the menu.

Rumi does her best to ignore that she's saying these lines to a *classmate* and offers, "Why of course! My favorite is the *Seolgi*

butter; I make it myself, and would be more than thrilled to share it with my ladies. It's a hand-picked mix of cardamom, clove, rose petals, and lavender, plus a hint of Korean influence through a pinch of dried jujube and fresh ginger."

Zoey's eyes practically sparkle. "Yes, that! That sounds amazing—oh, I didn't catch your name, Miss?"

"Artemis." Rumi calmly smooths her lapels. "As serene as the Greek goddess of the moon herself."

Lifting an eyebrow, Mira looks up. "Interesting name. What about the other butlers here?"

Not a common question, but not unheard of either. While the others aren't quite as concerned about the separation of their identities in and out of work as Rumi, they still notably maintain a character within the cafe itself. "Of course, my ladies. Across the way, you can see my dearest counterpart, Apollo, as bright as the sun. On the other side, you'll see Romance and Mystery; Romance is a bit of a flirt, and Mystery likes to remain an enigma. Would you care for any of them to serve you as well?"

Please say yes please say yes please say yes—

"Nah." Mira glances at Rumi, eying her, *clearly* taking in her appearance to judge and says, "I think we're more than happy with your service."

Great, Rumi thinks, screaming internally.

"How kind of you," says Rumi instead, betraying none of her own inner monologue or how it's mostly, well, screaming.

Somehow, miraculously, the afternoon spent serving Mira and Zoey passes rather seamlessly.

Jinu *was* right, in that they *are* Rumi's usual go-to in terms of tables she likes to serve. Rumi's far too busy with school for most kinds of relationships outside of her friendship with Jinu, so her favorite guests will always be those around her own age, and in particular, other women.

(And if they're attractive, as Zoey and Mira *are*, *especially* then maybe Rumi *especially* enjoys getting to play the charming attendant; after all, her guests have a great time in return, and it helps bolster business and word of mouth to boot.)

Rumi serves them tea and smiles, playing her role with aplomb while simultaneously scanning for any hints of recognition in their eyes—thankfully, all she seems to find is genuine interest, open friendliness and nothing else.

The two of them coo over the full afternoon sampler when it's brought, a tiered stand with three stacked plates featuring dainty finger sandwiches, quiches, earl gray scones, and an orange chocolate mousse that has the both of them nearly *moaning* in anticipation.

Zoey and Mira are easygoing guests, rarely using the table-provided hand bell to ring for Rumi's attention and serving themselves, flagging Rumi over by raising their hands instead and only when they have a genuine question about the cafe, a topic Rumi is more than happy to give explanations on.

This cafe, founded twelve years ago (though Rumi's only been working for three), is Celine's pride and joy, a passion project brought to life based purely on bringing enjoyment to the otherwise run ragged populace of southwestern Seoul, to give people a chance to kick back for an afternoon and enjoy being waited on and treated specially, to ensure that people can relax and leave with glowing smiles.

A little sappy, a little cheesy, but it's effective, and as tired as Rumi often is from school, it's hard not to feed off the energy of those

having fun around her;it' s practically *inf ectios* .

At long last, Zoey and Mira pay and take their leave, both grinning and even a little flushed as Rumi comes to take their plates and then lead them to the door. "I hope you had a wonderful afternoon tea here, my ladies."

"V ery wonderful! *S* lovely."

"It was nice."

"Enjoy the rest of your day ."Rumi bows one last time, waits for them to fully exit the cafe, and breathes a sigh of relief.

She did it! She survived!

Now, outside of occasional interactions in class and most definitely *not* the cafe, Rumill never have to worry about them again.

Oh, this cannot be happening.

A group project.

Lasting all semester.

In a group of two to four people.

In a class of strangers, where everyone naturally pairs up with their neighbors, which means that now Rumi is—

"W ould you like to be in our group?"Mira asks it kindly , and from anyone else, Rumi might think it pitying, because they already *ha* the minimum number of people, and they dont know Rumi at all, but from Mira, it just seems genuine and interested, and also the odds of Rumi finding literally anyone else in the class to partner up with, especially now, arent *gret* .

So, she opens her mouth to say a very tentative answer, something noncommittal that will give her a chance to think her way out of this situation of ending up in a group with two girls who she literally *served* yesterday as their *butler* and goes with:

"That sounds perfect! Thank you!"

What.

What.

Can Rumi strangle herself? She's never tried, and medically speaking she'd likely need tools, but in this particular moment, she's contemplating it more than she thinks she's ever contemplated anything in her life.

"Great!" Mira smiles, and okay, on top of *everything else*, it's entirely unfair that she and Zoey are so *pretty*.

Zoey whoops and pumps her fist in the air. "This is perfect! Oh, oh! Before we forget, let's exchange numbers real quick! Here!" She whips her phone out of her pocket and holds it out. Behind her, most students have cleared out with the end of class, groups established.

"Sure," Rumi says, taking Zoey's phone with hands that are *not* trembling and taking *calm*, *relaxed* breaths through her mask. She quickly plugs her number into the screen, then hands it back.

"Your name's Rumi, right?"

Rumi nods.

"I remembered, *score*! Oh, I also need your favorite animal."

"Mywait, what?"

Zoey repeats herself. "Your favorite animal!"

Chuckling, Mira adds, "For your contact. She thinks it's cute."

"Oh! Um."

"Come onnn, you've got to have a favorite!" Zoey bats her eyes at Rumi, lashes fluttering innocently.

Floundering, Rumi stutters, "Oh, um, I really like tardigrades? They're also called water bears, they're the first animal to survive in space, and there's actually thousands of them on the moon right now but they're probably all stuck in suspended animation unless they get retrieved and put back in water."

Zoey and Mira stare. "Okay so," Zoey says, "I dont think they , like, have emojis for that? But that fact is *so* cool, I am *begging* you to tell me more on that!"

Cheeks turning red, Rumi ducks her head and mutters, "Um, tiger is fine too. I think the stripes are cool."

"T iger, tiger done! Let me make a group chat real quick, and then you can save our numbers from there, and *then* we can get this show on the road!" Zoey chirps, voice as bright as the yellow of her hat. She sticks her tongue out as she puts the finishing touches on her text.

A vibrating buzz in Rumi' s pocket calls her attention, and she pulls it out to see two unknown numbers light up, each with a message giving the names to match said numbers for Rumi's own contacts.

"So, what' s your availability like?"

Rumi does a quick mental rundown on her schedule of shifts at the cafe all week except W ednesdays and Sundays, done by seven— and responds.

Mira nods, tapping her phone screen. "W ednesdays and Sundays it is. We're both free then. Y ou good to start next week?"

Yep. Yes. Itll be fine. Rumi' s got this.

"Sounds great!" She smiles, a little bit of her butler persona seeping through, and Zoey and Mira stare for an awkward beat before nodding their agreement.

As Rumi leaves campus for the afternoon, she reminds herself, over and over again, that it's *fine*.

It's not exactly like Mira and Zoey are going to come back to Honmoonlight Cafe anyway.

Zoey and Mira are back.

They're *back*.

Jinu's composure is wavering as he struggles to hold in his laughter as soon as he sees them.

However *this* time, he *is* free, and Rumi wastes no time in pointing this out.

"Fine, fine!" He holds his hands up in mock surrender. "I'll help out. But you owe me!"

Rumi watches carefully from around the corner to the kitchen and back hallway as Jinu greets Zoey and Mira with a bow, the perfect gentleman. They say something to him that she can't hear, but it's fine, because they're not her guests today, and—

Why is Jinu coming back?

"Oh, Artemis!" he calls in a singsongy voice. "You are *requested*."

Rumi stares at him in horror.

He grins back, all sharp teeth and delight, then slips away to one of his tables at the sound of a bell ringing for his attention.

Useless piece of—

Slipping out of the back hallway, Rumi steps into the cafe proper and squares her shoulders as Zoey and Mira wave.

They came back.

They came back in *under a week*.

What.

She's being pranked, she has to be.

"Hi Artemis!" Zoey greets cheerfully. Her bag is half-slung across one shoulder, and Mira stands behind her with a baseball cap and a cool demeanor that is as hot as it is intimidating (*not* that Rumi is thinking that right now).

"Agassi, it's wonderful to see you again. Welcome home."

"You too! Oo, I've been looking forward to coming back all week! I've been *dreaming* about that mousse." A dazed, far-off look enters Zoey's eyes.

Mira plucks Zoey's bag from her shoulder and hands it to Rumi. "She's not kidding either. I saw her drooling last night."

Rumi fights back a very unprofessional snort at the thought of Zoey drooling in bed, also making a note that the two of them must be roommates if Mira's seen Zoey asleep.

"Like *you* also haven't stopped talking about that special tea Artemis made for us last time!"

Mira coughs into her fist, turning to admire the decorations. "The tea was very good. I don't think that's unusual to admit."

Beckoning them inside to a table, Rumi preens a bit at the praise. "I'm glad you enjoyed it. It took me a long time and lots of taste-

testing to create that particular blend."

"Do you serve it to everyone?" Zoey slips into a seat at the table, Mira doing the same as Rumi hands them their menus and places Zoey's bag in a basket beneath her seat.

"Only to my favorite guests, of course," Rumi replies almost automatically, then finds herself a little unexpectedly flustered, the tips of her ears heating.

This is normal banter! She does this plenty!

At the same time, she cant help but feel both pleased and embarrassed as Zoey and Mira beam at the statement, like they believe it for some reason, which is *silly* and surely they know better, because it's also not like Rumi said that any more genuinely than she would to anyone else!

Much like the first time, they order the full afternoon tea set. Mira perks up immediately when Rumi arrives with her custom blend, setting two delicate porcelain tea cups before the two women and then carefully pouring steaming tea into each.

Mira brings her tea cup to her mouth and purses her lips to blow on it lightly—*not* that Rumi is watching Mira's lips~~th~~en seals them over the brim and takes a sip. She hums immediately with pleasure, and Rumi sparkles with pride.

"So, Artemis! What else do you do?" Zoey is curious, gaze intent with interest.

Rumi quickly responds with one of her standard, practiced answers. "Why, I'm here attending the estates each and every day, of course." She has a character to play, after all, no matter how nervous she is, or how attractive Zoey and Mira are.

For a brief moment, Zoey's face falls~~wa~~s she expecting a real answer?~~e~~ before perking back up again. "What does working the

estates look like?"

Falling back on more practiced answers, Rumi smoothly describes a fictional lifestyle as a butler in an old English manor, attending her wealthy lords and ladies with diligence and enthusiasm. She mentions her experiences with horseback riding (a lie) and fencing (a truth) and how she fell in love with the role of serving as a butler because of the smiles and praise she receives in return (another truth).

Though she has other guests to attend to, Rumi finds herself drawn consistently back to Zoey's and Mira's table to chat further, something she's not normally prone to doing without the ring of the table's provided hand bell;Rumi' s *a*~~s~~*lso* noticed that, yet again, Zoey and Mira dont use it, instead choosing to watch and wave Rumi over instead.

And it's not like Rumi minds the bell~~it'~~ s useful, serving both a function and form factor for the cafe's proper aesthetic~~,~~but there' s something familiar and personal in the way Zoey and Mira flag her down like a friend more than anything else.

Which! Is silly! Because they are her guests!

Even if they *a*~~re~~ very friendly ones, and even if Rumi *is* enjoying their company (and also sweating bullets because oh god what if she slips up and they recogni*z*~~s~~e her and she' s literally meeting them tomorrow for their project and~~).~~

This is their second visit.

Hopefully their last.

When it's time to see them off, Rumi leads them to the door, bowing, and both smile and cheerfully declare, "See you next time!"

Ah.

Rumi's maybe just a *little* tiny bit in trouble.

Rumi triple-checks her appearance in her dorm's mirror before heading out to the campus library: her blue hood is pulled tight around her head, disguising her rather conspicuously purple hair, she's got a simple face mask on, and her eyes are a nondescript brown, far less notable without her gold contacts.

This is fine. There's no way theyll look at her and connect her with Artemis the butler.

As she walks across campus, adjusting the straps of her laptop bag, she ducks her head and ponders Jinu's comment on it "not being that big a deal."

Annoyingly, he's *probably* right. Zoey and Mira seem like nice people, and for some odd reason are *clearly* enjoying the experience of visiting a butler cafe, so it's hardly like they'd mock Rumi for it.

But what if they were upset?

She's served them *twice* now, and didnt say anything either time! Which like, okay, that could also technically be excused by her job, because it's not like she's supposed to break character;also she *couldnt*, because she's a *professional* (and Celine would give her a look of Severe Disappointment and Rumi doesnt think she can survive one of those again, not since last time when she was eleven and had the bright idea of fencing an imaginary opponent right in front of a rather expensive vase).

She should just tell them. Rip the bandage off. Bite the bullet. Fall on her knees and offer up her sword or whatever.

Lost in thought, Rumi absentmindedly swipes her student card at the library gates and slips inside, immediately darting for the stairs towards the private study rooms on the second floor (Mira had texted

she'd booked one in advance). She passes rows and rows of shelves stacked high with books of all kinds imaginable and spots Zoey and Mira through a small window in the door.

She slips inside, shutting the door behind her with a soft click and smiling politely in greeting before realizing they can't actually *see* that beneath her mask. "Um, good afternoon," she squeaks out instead, wincing internally at how awkward it came out. Her literal job is to be professionally smooth, so *why* is she acting like such a fool right now?

Thankfully, neither girl seems to mind. "Hi Rumi! Perfect timing! We were just pulling up potential topics and digging for old examples from last year." Zoey flips her laptop screen around to show a lengthy list as Rumi pulls out a chair and sits herself at the round table.

"Are you cold?" Mira cocks her head, eying Rumi closely.

Flushing, Rumi shakes her head. "No, I'm good!"

"Okay. We can always adjust the temps in here if you need us too, it's really no big deal—"

Rumi waves her hands in front of her face. "No, no, I'm good, I promise! I just run cold, is all!" She tugs her hood a little more securely around her face.

Mira squints at her for a moment, then shrugs. "Suit yourself. So anyway—"

She launches right into it, explaining what she and Zoey have already been talking about, and they don't want to actually do anything without Rumi's input, but they haven't been able to stop themselves from spitballing ideas while they're back in their dorm.

Which also confirms Rumi's thoughts. "Are you two roommates?"

"Yes," Mira states matter-of-factly.

Giggling, Zoey adds, "We're also girlfriends." She playfully swats at Mira, who grins and leans back.

"That too."

Rumi swallows, a little caught up in the way they're both grinning at each other. It's obvious that they've got a clear bond, and it sends a surge of infectious affection in Rumi's chest. "That's wonderful," she says, and finds herself a little surprised at how much she means it.

It's clear that Zoey and Mira are appreciative, from the way a tension Rumi hadn't clocked at all leaves their shoulders.

Oh. They weren't sure, were they?

How can Rumi let them know—

"I worked a Pride event last year—let me know if you want info when it rolls around again!" Sure, yes, mention the Pride event she worked *promotionally* as another, yeah, that's a great idea, totally!

All the same, it *does* get the desired reaction. Their eyes sparkle knowingly, and Rumi didn't even have to reveal her own preferences! That's a success, right?

Oh, thinking on it, she probably could've just flashed the blue, purple, and pink-striped sword pin on her bag.

Well.

It's fine.

Despite giving away a little more information than Rumi maybe should've, it undeniably sets the overall atmosphere at ease. These *are* strangers, and Rumi's not exactly being as charming as she's trained to be, but whatever she's doing *is* working, and really, that's all that matters.

"I think we'll take you up on that," Mira says, scribbling a note to herself that Rumi definitely doesn't gulp anxiously at. "What work did you do?"

Ah.

That.

Should've been an anticipated follow-up question.

Scratching her cheek through the mask, Rumi laughs nervously. "Just a small business that my guardian owns."

"Guardian?"

"Mhm. She took me in and raised me after my mom passed when I was a kid."

Zoey's face falls. "Oh, I'm so sorry, I didn't mean to—"

Frantically, Rumi shakes her head and flails her arms. "No, no, it's fine! It was a long time ago! I wouldn't have mentioned it otherwise—sorry, I didn't mean to make things awkward, I—"

A calm hand settles on Rumi's shoulder, providing a gentle but firm pressure. "Relax." Mira's voice is low and soothing. "You didn't make anything awkward. Take a breath."

Rumi does.

"Thank you for sharing," Zoey says, light but sincere. "But okay, I think I've distracted us long enough. The project!" She claps her hands together. "So, what are your thoughts on—"

Grateful, Rumi inclines her head and listens intently as Zoey and Mira show their ideas, then offers her own thoughts, shifting into a more relaxed, comfortable version of herself as she focuses on what she knows, finding confidence in knowing her studies the way she finds it as Artemis.

By the time their session finishes, the three of them have their topic and the beginnings of an outline, and Rumi leaves holding her head high with success and excitement.

Weeks pass.

Every Wednesday, they get together to work on the project, and Rumi finds herself relaxing more and more around them.

Zoey is bright and bubbly and witty, always offering a new angle or remembering some obscure bit of info that helps give a new perspective.

Mira is warm and soothing and watchful, always calmly keeping Zoey and Rumi on track when they get distracted by tangents and qietly pointing out where they need to keep improving.

And Rumi, for all that she's still not even properly shown her face around them, has settled into a rhythm, enjoying that they let her direct and delegate as needed, recogniing her own expertise in the topic and field and willingly letting her lead instead of butting heads. Rumi hadnt gone in expecting to take charge, but she' s slipped into the role naturally with the other two, and they make her feel worthy of it in a way she hopes she proves she *is*.

While it's only in the beginning stages, the project is going great.

What's *not* going great is the fact that Mira and Zoey have *becom*e *cae regla*s .

And they reqest Artemis *every tim*e .

Rumi has no idea what to make of this.

She's stopped panicking, at the very least, but *h*w is she doing and *h*w did she find herself in this situation?

Without fail, Rumi can tell by Jinu's snickering that Zoey and Mira have arrived for the afternoon yet again. He doesn't even have to tell Rumi they're here anymore, just looks at her with the *stupidest* expression on his face as he bites back his laughter, and Rumi just sighs and grabs two menus.

Today's even worse than normal because it's a special fall-and-kind-of-Halloween-but-not-really themed week for the cafe, so Rumi's wearing various tiger accessories and make-up, and though Zoey and Mira have been nothing but nice, she can't help but flush slightly at the realization that they're about to see her in this.

As soon as she opens the door for them, they both grin broadly. "Artemis, hi~~-~~hhhhh my god, are those *ears*? You look so *cute*!" Zoey squeals, curling her hands under her chin and cooing.

Even Mira lets out a quiet, "You *do* look cute," that has the tips of Rumi's ears undoubtedly turning red; she casually flips her loose hair so it covers them.

To Rumi's surprise, a light pink blooms across the bridge of Mira's nose, and a similar one sneaks beneath the freckles of Zoey's cheeks.

Coughing into a gloved fist, Rumi pretends she doesn't hear Jinu snort loudly and *unprofessionally* behind her and says, "Thank you, my ladies. Yes, this week we're celebrating All Hallow's Eve. We have some new seasonal dishes to accompany this special occasion, if you'd like to take a look? Come in, of course~~-~~your usual table?"

"Yes please!"

Rumi leads them back to the same booth they've come to prefer, off in the corner where they can survey the entire cafe but feel like they have their own space.

As soon as they're seated, Rumi sets the menus carefully in front of them, gesturing elegantly at the new menu items and explaining what each one is.

"How am I supposed to *choose*?" Zoey licks her lips. "I was looking forward to another mousse, but now I have no idea what to pick! The blackberry and apple crumble sounds delicious, but also there's the Yorkshire parkin, and then *this*!" She points aggressively at a picture of a toffee apple dyed orange and decorated like a pumpkin.

"If only," Mira teases, "there was a very wise and knowledgeable butler with a one hundred percent success rate nearby to help tell us *her* favorite." She glances slyly at Rumi.

Straightening her bow, Rumi smiles calmly, no matter how much she may be panicking inwardly because *how* was that tone and look from Mira? She's dating Zoey, isn't she? But it's like Mira's determined to be as charming as Rumi is, and wow does she have a knack for it; even *if* Rumi didn't know how kind she was as a group project partner, she has no doubt Mira would be just as effective. (Again, the idea of Mira and Zoey in butler suits springs to mind.)

"Of course, Mira," Rumi says, then freezes. "*My lady*," she corrects herself, voice cracking as Mira smiles widely and turns to Rumi, propping her chin in her hand.

Mira tuts playfully. "Tsk tsk, Artemis. Addressing me by name?"

Rumi's mouth opens and closes. "My apologies, my lady. It won't happen again."

Leaning forward, Mira practically purrs, "And what if I want it to?"

A loud *bak* sounds as Zoey brings her menu down on the top of Mira's head.

Mira yelps, sitting up straight and rubbing her head. "*Zoey!*"

"Stop teasing her ," hisses Zoey , glancing apologetically at Rumi. "If that was too far, please let us know, we dont want to make you uncomfortable."

Was it too far?

From another guest, Rumi might feel uncomfortable, yes, but right now, she's reminded that no, she's not uncomfortable;she' s just really, *really* attracted to women.

Rumi clears her throat. "No, no, both of you are fine. I dont mind, really, but I appreciate you looking out."And then, before she can think better of it, her *stupid* mouth opens and she adds, "This is why *you're* my favorite guests."

Both of their cheeks turn bright red.

Taking deep breaths, Rumi smiles and stays *so professional* and takes their orders and immediately darts to the back to splash water on her face as Jinu appears out of nowhere to come and laugh.

It's getting a little harder, after maybe two month's worth of study sessions on this project, to sit with Mira and Zoey while bundled up in the same hoodie and mask and pretend like she isnt actively flirting with them regularly while disguised as a butler in a paid cafe.

Today is a bit different from usual. They're out at a park on the campus grounds, seated at an empty picnic table under the shade of a towering maple, an autumn breeze lightly tossing the fabric of Rumi's hood and curling the corners of her notebook.

Mira's off grabbing some drinks from a nearby vending machine, leaving just Rumi and Zoey together, taking a break and resting their brains after working them all afternoon on furthering their project.

Zoey twirls a pen between her fingers. Occasionally it falls, clattering on the wooden planks, before she quickly picks it back up again. "I've been meaning to ask you—do you have any other cool animal facts like that one about the water bears?"

Standing and stretching next to the bench, Rumi bends over to reach for her toes, idly noting the red and yellow leaves dappling the dirt at her feet. She shakes her head. "Not really. Like, animals specifically? Because honestly, I knew that one more because of the moon relation."

"Oo, the moon! Do you have any cool *moon* facts?"

Rumi laughs. Her hood pulls back a little as she stands up and drops casually into a half lunge. She readjusts it, then crosses one arm across her chest and holds it there. "A few! It's been a special interest of mine since I was little. My mom used to tell me all sorts of stories about it. We'd sit together during Chuseok and make wishes."

When Rumi glances at the table, she startles at Zoey fully facing her, eyes sparkling with attention. "That sounds lovely! *My* parents skipped that one when I was little because we were in America. Plus, they were too busy preparing for Halloween despite it being, like, a *month* later."

"Really?" Rumi tilts her head.

"Oh yeah." Zoey nods aggressively. "It's *huge* over there! Giant skeletons, more candy than you could eat in a lifetime, and *so* many costumes! I do miss it, although there's this *really* cute cafe Mira and I have been going to recently that's done some dress-up for it!"

Really cute—*oh no*.

"Are you telling Rumi about Honmoonlight Cafe?" Mira looks over the both of them as she returns, setting three drinks on the table—a lemon-lime soda for Zoey, a milk soda for Rumi, and a sports drink for herself.

Play dumb.

Play dumb.

"What's that?" Rumi closes her eyes briefly and sends a silent thanks to the moon for the fact that she's wearing a face mask, or else her strained smile would've given her away in a heartbeat.

"Don't judge, okay it's this themed cafe over on Nokdu Street! It's like an old English manor where they serve afternoon tea sets, and the food and tea is *delicious* and"—

"It's a butler cafe," Mira interrupts bluntly.

Zoey gasps in offense, then shrugs. "Okay, yes, it's a butler cafe. I'm not sure if you've ever been to one before, but they're actually *so* fun! We went on a whim because my brother was badgering me he just watched this old anime and wanted me to go visit one so he could hear about it firsthand since they're not exactly a thing back in Burbank and really, it's actually super pretty inside, and everything tastes *so so* good, and there's this one butler who's like, stunningly gorg"—

Mira elbows Zoey roughly.

"Great and nice! So nice! I know it's, like, her character, but she looks like she's having fun I hope she's having fun and anyway, we've sort of made it a habit to start visiting now." Zoey turns to Mira. "Do you think we're her favorite customers? I hope so, but I'm sure she's just as sweet to everyone, she's always *so* professional, and—*mph*!"

The sound of Zoey's voice is abruptly muffled as Mira closes her palm over Zoey's mouth. "Another time, Zoey. I'm not sure how interested Rumi is, and we *do* have a project to work on."

Yanking Mira's hand away, Zoey adds, "Okay, well, if you *are* interested, you should let us know! I think you'd like it! I mean, we

like it~~s~~eriously , it's so fun, I think it's probably pretty cool to work there and—*oh*! It even has a moon theme! It's *liter~~a~~lly* perfect. But yes, project!"She begins to turn her attention back to their work.

Rumi pulls her hood a little tighter around her face as Zoey talks, hoping it's effective enough in hiding the red on her cheeks as she recalls helping Celine pick out the theming of the cafe when she first purchased the shop. They'd stood together in the empty main room of the vacant second floor, surveying and brainstorming how to make it their own, when Rumi suggested theming it to the moon, to honor her mom.

Celine had smiled, bent down, hugged Rumi tightly, and whispered, "That' s a wonderful idea. Let's do it."

▶ 🎨

"I actually think we should invite her next time."

"Y ou think?"

Rumi does her best to hold a straight face as she walks past Zoey's and Mira's table, a tea set in hand for another group of guests nearby.

Were they talking about inviting *h~~e~~r* ?

To *h~~e~~re* ?

Because that~~th~~at' s a problem.

Rumi likes to think she's rather talented;maybe it' s conceit, but she's damn good at what she does here as a butler, at studying and scoring well in her classes, *~~a~~nd* fencing (even if she's had to drop

participating as a team member in order to focus on her studies and her work).

But she's not talented enough to be in *two places at once*.

Taking a quick breather in the back, she hisses what she overheard to Jinu.

He stares a moment, then doubles over laughing.

Rumi sneers. Absolutely *useless*.

At the end of class, Mira's the one who suggests it first. "Hey, Rumi. You know that cafe Zoey—"

"*We!*"

"—mentioned last week?"

Rumi tucks her laptop in her bag and zips it up. "Oh, uh, the butler cafe?"

"How do you feel about studying there together on Wednesday instead of the library? Might be a nice change of pace, and you can try my favorite tea out."

Say no.

"Plus, you'll get to meet our favorite butler!"

Say no.

"It'll be really fun!"

Say no.

"Sure, sounds great!"

K .

"W elcome home, my lad*E*—" Jinu sputters, voice jumping an octave in a crack to rival the sqeak of his teenage years, and all Rumi can do is draw inwards on herself, crossing her arms over her chest and hunching as small as she can.

Struggling desperately to save face, Jinu turns away and coughs several times. When he turns back, his eyes are watering a little, and Rumi begins plotting all the different ways she can murder him during tomorrow's shift.

"My apologies," Jinu says, recovering smoothly, "I fear I had something caught in my throat. As I was saying, welcome home, my ladies. Before you ask, I'm afraid to inform you that the lovely Artemis is out today. She's running errands in the countryside."

Zoey's and Mira's faces both immediately fall, and Rumi fidgets at how crestfallen they look.

"If my ladies are okay with the lovely Artemis' counterpart, I'll be more than happy to serve you today."

Rumi fights a groan. Of *course* Jinu's taking her table. Why wouldn't he?

She supposes that's better than someone like Abby (sweet, but dense and a little too self-centered for Rumi's liking), or even worse, *Bar**ce*— his whole bit is flirting with guests, but something about the idea of him doing that with Zoey and Mira raises her hackles.

"I see you brought a new guest today," Jinu says, gesturing to take their bags and leading them inside. "My name is Apollo. It's a pleasure to have you join us today."

Rumi grits her teeth until Zoey lightly nudges her ankle. "Uh, right. Thank you, *Apollo* ."

He flashes his brightest smile at her.

The question, Rumi considers as she follows to their table, is what the most efficient method to kill him will be. She's torn between strangling him with his bowtie or framing unprofessionalism and setting Celine loose.

Jinu leads them to a table that's *not* their usual one, Rumi notes disdainfully, but she doesn't protest because she's not exactly supposed to *know* , and Zoey and Mira don't say anything either , each pulling out a fancy cushioned chair and sitting around a round table covered in a blue tablecloth.

He runs through the standard spiel, handing them their menus and giving his own personal recommendations for tea, including the unique blend he himself makes, just like Rumi makes hers.

Mira frowns at that. "Sorry , Apollo, but I was actually hoping to show our friend here Artemis' usual. Do you know how to prepare it too?"

Jinu's lips twitch.

Rumi stares at him from beneath her hood.

Does he seriously not—

"My apologies," he says, bowing his head and deliberately avoiding eye contact with Rumi. "I'm afraid only Artemis knows that recipe."

"Do you think maybe she has it written down somewhere?"

Jinu shakes his head sadly. "No, Artemis has a tendency to retain it all in her head. Very private, that one."

"She's more private than the others here?" Zoey asks curiously .

Still avoiding looking at Rumi, Jinu nods. "Oh, absolutely. She's rather mysterious, maybe even more so than our wonderful butler Mystery. I really do apologize that I can't provide her special tea for you."

"Are you *sure* she wouldn't have written it down?" Rumi grits out, pursing her lips beneath her face mask.

"Positive." Jinu nods sagely. "*So many secrets*, that one."

He's dead. She's going to kill him. She's going to kill him completely dead.

"So there's *no way* that she could've written it down in, say, some kind of *butler handbook*? That's *all of you* reference?" Rumi hisses, ignoring the odd looks Zoey and Mira are shooting her way.

"Now that's a rather silly concept, my lady. A butler handbook! What are the chances we—" Jinu pauses, eyes widening. "*Oh*. Oh! Yes! Right! The, um, the *etiquette guide*, yes, surely there's something in there. Allow me to go check. I'll be right back." He darts away rather unelegantly towards the back area for the literal employee handbook that he somehow forgot existed.

Rumi wonders how many times she can smack him in the head with it before the material within it sticks.

Doing her best to pretend that she wasn't acting weirdly a moment ago, Rumi smiles awkwardly beneath her mask and changes the topic from Jinu. "Uh, sorry that your favorite butler isn't here today."

Zoey slumps onto the table, letting out a low whine. "Me *too*! Rumi, she's *so* nice, and like, *really* pretty. I know that's not a *great* reason, but Mira agrees with me!"

Rumi blinks as Zoey's *literal* girlfriend nods her head resolutely. "Zoey's right. To clarify, that's not why we request her. She's

genuinely just very good at this, and delightful company. But she's *also* gorgeous, yes."

Pretty? *Gorgeous?*

And okay, Rumi knows how she looks, she knows she's quite a few people's type—maybe everyone's—but it's one thing to hold that confidence in her appearance and another to hear it from her classmates-turned-friends over the past couple of months.

Zoey and Mira are both really, really pleasant company that Rumi enjoys a lot, and sure, it's been a little odd and stressful that she sometimes serves them dressed as a butler and they aren't aware of this, but that aside, she likes spending time with them.

They make her smile.

Beneath her disguise, she can't help but smile yet again, grateful that her blush is obscured by her face mask and hood, because, well, they think she's pretty!

(And considering how beautiful *they* are, it's an even higher compliment, truly.)

Anyway, this is fine.

Rumi's fine.

Oh, she should respond, shouldn't she?

Change the topic.

"Well, then I'm sad to have missed her." Thinking a moment, she slyly adds, "How does she compare to Apollo?"

"She doesn't." Mira snorts. "He's not even close to her level."

Zoey whaps Mira's shoulder and hisses, "Don't be *mean*! He's nice! And decently cute!"

"Decently cute" vs "supermodel hot" isn't exactly a fair comparison."

Rumi chokes on air, pounding her chest for a second as Jinu chooses that exact moment to reappear with a tray and the ordered tea on it. He approaches from behind Mira and Zoey, close enough to hear. Making eye contact with a sputtering Rumi, he flashes her a scowl before immediately plastering on a show smile as he comes into the others' view.

"Your tea, my ladies," he says, bowing and serving before politely reminding that, if they need him, all they need to do is ring the small hand bell on the table.

Ducking her head and pulling her mask down, Rumi takes a sip of the tea and wrinkles her nose. Of *course* he used the wrong ratio of clove to cardamom.

Across the table, Mira makes a near identical expression and sighs. "Sorry, Rumi," she begins, glaring daggers at the teacup, "but this is *not* the same quality as normal; I think we'll have to bring you here again to—" She trails off.

Rumi licks her lips with another small grimace and looks up to see Mira staring at her. Flustered, Rumi quickly pulls her mask back up. "Sorry, did I have something on my face, or—?"

"No." Mira shifts her weight in her seat. Next to her, Zoey gives her an odd look. "It's just, I haven't seen you with your mask down. You almost reminded me of—nevermind, sorry, that's silly."

Zoey is glancing back and forth between Rumi and Mira, brows furrowed.

Sweating beneath her hoodie, Rumi awkwardly snatches the hand bell and rings it. "Maybe the desserts will be better?"

That seems to do the trick.

Zoey and Mira immediately perk up, raving about their favorite foods and then giving their order to Jinu as soon as he arrives.

Partway through the afternoon, Rumi decides to take revenge on Jinu, and begins to utilize the bell any time a single dish is finished so he can come clean it.

After maybe the third time, Rumi flushes, self-conscious at how this might look to Zoey and Mira. "Oh, um. Am I doing this right?"

"I dont *thnk* so," Zoey answers, squinting. "But we've never really used it before! Artemis is always watching our table very closely."

"Here, let me try." Mira holds out her hand for the bell and gives it a little shake. It peals across the cafe space and Jinu perks and turns, wearing his usual smile.

"Yes?" he says, approaching.

"Oh, nothing," Mira replies, shrugging nonchalantly. "I just wanted to try it out. My bad."

Rumi does her best to hide her snicker as Jinu gives a prim and proper smile and bow, then ducks away.

Other than the fact that Artemis is conveniently absent and Jinu cant seem to make her tea correctly~~so~~mething Rumi *will* have words with him about later~~the~~ afternoon sails by with general merriment along with the requisite focus for their project.

They munch on custard tarts as they research more and continue combining their notes and thoughts in the rhythm they've found with each other since starting.

It's easy, and fun, and relaxing. Rumi gets a few more bell rings in to pester Jinu properly, but otherwise, the afternoon is spent enjoying good food and good company.

The corners of Rumi's eyes crinkle above her mask as she smiles and laughs until it's time to head out.

Nervously, Rumi clutches her bag to her chest with one hand while the other hovers in front of the door for dorm room number 86.

She just needs to knock.

It's fine!

All of the study rooms in the library happen to be booked out today, and it's pouring rain outside, so someone's place is the next logical choice, and Rumi lives in a small apartment adjoining Celine's off-campus that'd be a lot less convenient than joining Zoey and Mira in their dorm in Banak-sa, one of the main campus buildings.

Hanging her umbrella on a hook outside the door, Rumi pats her hoodie and mask, takes a deep breath, and knocks.

The door *f lings* open, so fast that Rumi stumbles backwards in shock.

"Rumi!" Zoey greets excitedly, bouncing on the balls of her feet. "Come in, come in! Are you wet? Do you need to change? It's coming down like *cra* out there!" The pattering of rain against the window is a constant drumming beneath Zoey's cheerful voice.

Rumi shakes her head. "I have an umbrella, so I'm mostly fine. No dripping all over your dorm, I promise."

Zoey's lips quirk to the side in a smirk and she opens her mouth to say something before immediately thinking better of it. "Well, come on in! We've even got snacks—you like Banana Kicks, right? And milk soda?"

Flattered that they remember her favorites, Rumi nods, slipping her shoes off in the entryway and feeling the slightly sticky damp of her

hoodie, wishing desperately that she could take it off for once but knowing that there's simply *no* explaining the long, lavender braid she has hidden within it.

She takes a moment to survey the dorm room itself. It's simple and relatively tidy, though she does note a small laundry pile conspicuously swept up under one of the beds. On the walls are posters of music groups, movies, and several goofy medical-themed ones of baby animals reciting bad puns (featuring hits like "maul-practice", "cat-atostrophe", and "reptile dysfunction").

There's an army of plushies on one bed, and a slightly smaller army on the other lofted above it, two desks, and a slightly ajar closet door revealing a startling amount of pink. A skateboard rests up against the wall, cartoon turtles peek out beneath a blanket from the top bunk, and a handful of bows and ribbon frame a corkboard pinned full with photos of Zoey and Mira and, to Rumi's immense shock, *her* : from the day at the park, where she's stretching and laughing while talking to Zoey.

The room is more spacious than Rumi expected, with just enough space for two desks up against the wall, a TV and stand in between, and a plush carpet with a couple of bean bags and other assorted, cushioned seating scattered atop it.

It's cozy and lived-in, and more than anything else, it looks and feels like *Zoey* and *Mira* .

Mira swivels around in her desk chair, wearing an over-sized pajama shirt with a grumpy looking polar bear on the front. "Rumi, welcome!" She pushes a pair of gold-rimmed glasses up the bridge of her nose ~~Ru~~mi's never seen her wear them before, and she can't help but think that Mira looks rather cute with them on. "Sit wherever you'd like, we're not exactly picky."

Picking the round bowl chair, Rumi takes a seat as Zoey flops entirely onto the floor, starfishing and blowing her bangs out of her face.

Zoey stares at the ceiling, then strains her neck so she can view Rumi upside down and beams. "Did you know you're officially the first person we've had come visit us?"

Rumi shakes her head, eyes widening.

Zoey nods as best as she can in her awkward position. "To be fair, it's mostly because there's usually a mess, but Mira and I both worked very hard to clean up as fast as we could before you arrived."

"*Zoey*," admonishes Mira, sighing in exasperation as Rumi snorts. "Way to show our whole ass," she mutters.

Zoey lifts her arm and flaps her hand flippantly in the air. "Oh pssh, what's it matter? We've been meeting up biweekly since September, I'm *pretty* sure Rumi doesn't care."

"It's true, I don't. Honestly, I think my place is messier."

"*You?*" Mira lifts an eyebrow in disbelief.

Rumi shrugs, setting her bag on the floor beside her. "I get that a lot. Just because I'm maybe a *little* particular about some things doesn't mean I'm, like, perfectly neat and tidy."

"No?" Zoey rolls over and props her head in her palms, using her elbows to brace on the carpet. "No offense—seriously, this is a compliment, I swear—but you always seem like you're doing *something*. Your schedule's gotta be crazy packed between your mysterious work that you won't tell us about and school, right?"

"A little."

"So what do you do for *fun*, to *relax*?"

Rumi muses. "I used to be on a fencing team, and still practice when I can? Sang in a choir. Oh, and I used to participate in, like, four language clubs and practice piano."

Scoffing, Mira shakes her head. "What are you, a border collie? Is that what you're hiding beneath your hoodie? Black and white fur and a big fluffy tail?"

Rumi laughs, caught off-guard. "No, I just don't like sitting still!" she argues, vehement but light-hearted.

"Oo, Mira's right, you *are* like a border collie! They always have to do a job or else they go stir-crazy."

Rumi protests, "I don't go *stir-crazy*, I just like doing things! I'm sitting still right now!"

Zoey sits up properly and sticks her tongue out. "Technical nuance!"

"*Fact*." And it's interesting, Rumi wonders, how she's already come to feel so relaxed around these two, enough to banter the way she and Jinu do, playful teasing that stems from a mutual fondness.

And considering they took her to the cafe, unknowingly called her gorgeous, and are looking at her right now, with wide grins, Rumi's pretty confident that yeah, this fondness is *very* mutual.

"Mm, sorry Zoey, I do think Rumi's got you beat with that one," Mira hums, eyes glinting mischievously as Zoey gasps.

"The betrayal? From my *girlfriend* of all people?!"

"The unfortunate truth. She is, in fact, sitting still. Rumi's won this round."

Still teasingly offended, Zoey makes a face at Mira, and Rumi can't help but giggle as she watches them go back and forth, an entertaining mix of banter and flirting that, oddly, doesn't make Rumi feel separated: instead, she feels honored at being truly allowed a place in this world they've created together.

Safe from the gray, dreary outside world, rain still steadily tapping against the window, Rumi lets herself relax for once and enjoys the

coziness of the dorm and the comfort of her present company.

"Artemis, we have a question for you actually."

Rumi pauses, carefully setting the tea pot she's holding on the table before delicately folding her hands in front of her and giving a small bow. "Of course, my ladies. How may I be of assistance?"

"So, we have this friend," Zoey begins, and Rumi does her best not to furrow her brows, a little confused by this start, "that Mira and I have been getting to know this semester—she's in our class, and we paired up with her for a group project—and anyway, she's *really* sweet and smart, and we were thinking that we—well, it's hard to explain, um, it's"—

Mira leans over and lightly taps the underside of Zoey's jaw, who closes it sheepishly. "We really like her and want to spend some time with her doing something a little more relaxed than studying. Do *you* have any suggestions?"

Oh god, they're asking about *her*.

Blinking owlishly, Rumi falters. "Oh. Well, I suppose *how* you want to is important. You said to do something more relaxing? Do you know what she likes?"

"Studying, but also she knows a lot of really cool, obscure facts! Especially about the moon! Oh, and swords. I think she fences? Uh, she also mentioned singing, I think?" Zoey scrunches her nose, deep in thought.

Is this, like, ethical for Rumi to secretly weigh in on this?

Well, it's the same as if they're asking Rumi what she herself wants to do, if she *really* thinks about it. So it's probably fine.

Zoey's pretty spot-on with what Rumi likes (minus, naturally, playing the role of butler in a themed cafe), but neither the moon nor swords make for easy outings. Singing though Rumi hasn't sung in front of anyone in a couple of years, but Mira and Zoey make her feel comfortable, and pridefully, Rumi *does* remember having a knack for it.

"How about karaoke?"

Mira snaps her fingers. "That's it! Thank you, Artemis."

A little bewildered and guilty at having suggested her own outing, Rumi shoves the anxiety aside, smiles and says, "Any time."

Karaoke turns out to have been the perfect suggestion.

In their own private room for the next two hours, the three of them sing their hearts out, each choosing a wide variety of favorite songs to perform, ranging from K-pop to American rap to children's show Pororo's theme song to, of all things, a *seasalty* .

It takes Rumi a moment or two to warm up, but once she has, she launches into her favorite tracks, belting enthusiastically and swelling with confidence as Zoey's and Mira's jaws drop with each higher and higher note.

In a way, Rumi almost feels like she's performing, playing a role just like she is each week at the Honmoonlight Cafe.

Here and now, she's an idol. It doesn't matter that she's bundled in a hoodie with a face mask tugged around her chin she's striding around the booths and slipping into simple dance moves as if she's on stage herself, grinning wildly and feeding off the cheers and starstruck expressions of her new friends.

When it's Zoey's turn, she bounces around, alternating between striving for similarly high notes and spitting rapid-fire verses with the hand motions to match. Mira settles for more electronic tracks with instrumental breaks in the middle so she can show off her dance moves~~an~~d *wow* does she have a lot! (She tells them, a little embarrassed, that she used to attend lots of random play dances—public fan events dancing to snippets of K-pop songs~~in~~ high school. Zoey and Rumi give her a standing ovation, laughing as she hisses at them to sit back down.)

Outside of spending time with Celine and Jinu, Rumi's not really had friends like this in her life, people that she sees and spends time with regularly, that have her looking forward to their meetings together—and she *does*, she really does.

There's still the whole looming awkward secret bit, but ignoring that, Rumi spends the evening laughing and grateful to have another childhood wish fulfilled at last.

For the first time *ever* since Mira and Zoey have become Honmoonlight Cafe regulars, Rumi is too busy to take their table.

A whole group of tourists came in just a half hour earlier, and Rumi's maximum was reached near instantly. Even Celine is out now and serving guests, a rather uncommon sight but always a rare treat to see a master at work, and Jinu's been back from a ~~q~~ick fifteen minute break for all of thirty seconds before Mira and Zoey arrive.

Rumi does her best to keep an eye on them, something possessive snarling in her chest that she can't attend them like normal, but at least it's *Jinu* grabbing them and not Abby~~or~~ worse, their newest hire, a fresh out of high school teenager who's chosen the moniker *Boy*.

The sound of bells ringing at tables pulls her every which way, and though she does her best to sneak smiles and waves every time she

passes Zoey and Mira, she can't spare more than that. She darts around, polite and professional and diligent, and while she used to revel in busy days like this, right now, she's fighting not to openly sulk that she can't attend Zoey and Mira.

The rest of Jinu's guests begin to clear out, enough that he can relax a little more, and Rumi narrows her eyes as she catches him not just serving Zoey and Mira but *chatting*, because really, what could he *possibly* have to talk to them about?

He won't tell on her, of that much Rumi's certain. As much as Rumi gives him grief and he does the same, they're each other's best friends~~ha~~ve been since high school~~an~~d she trusts him unequivocally. (And if that means sometimes she trusts him to be exceptionally *annoying*, well, that's a form of love in its own way too.)

Right now, what she trusts is that he's up to no good.

Rumi's likely to assume this of him on any given day, but today she *knows* it to be true the instant he catches her staring from across the cafe and gives her a wide, mischievous, Cheshire Cat grin.

What.

No.

What is he doing?

Rumi smiles brightly to her customers but inwardly she's swearing enough to make a sailor proud as she starts to notice Jinu casually conversing with Zoey and Mira *every single time* she passes them.

What are they *talking* about?

It's driving Rumi insane.

Occasionally, she catches a couple of small snippets.

~~"~~friend of ours~~"~~—

“has to be special”—

“— *think* she’s interested”—

“no, but we can start dropping hints about being open to a”—

“maybe just ask her straight out”—

Try as she might, she can’t seem to piece the snippets together into anything intelligible; by the end of the shift, when all guests have cleared out and it’s time to clean up the cafe and rest for tomorrow, Rumi is frustrated and desperate.

Cornering Jinu up against a table, Rumi angles her head and narrows her eyes. “What were you talking about with Zoey and Mira?”

Jinu lets his weight relax onto his palms, leaning back on the table like he wasn’t actively boxed against it. He flashes white teeth in a sly grin. “Why, general chatter, of course!”

“That’s bullshit.” Rumi jabs him in the chest with her index finger. “They had *no* interest in talking to you last time. What changed?”

“Nothing changed! I simply offered a listening ear for a problem I heard them puzzling about how to solve.”

“A problem?” Rumi frowns. “Like our project?”

Jinu hums, shrugging. “Something related to it, yeah.”

“What would *you* know about Biochemistry?”

“Absolutely nothing, obviously.”

Rumi grits her teeth and growls, “Then *how* was the problem?”

Shaking his head, Jinu tsks. “Now Rumi, it’s rather unprofessional to spill conversations about our guests, isn’t it?”

Rumi balls her hands into fists and stamps her foot, glaring sourly. "*iJhLu* "she scolds, opening her mouth and preparing to really lay into him in the hopes that she can scare an answer when—

"Rumi. Jinu. Why arent you two cleaning up?" Celine' s voice is qiet, but it cuts through the air like a mystical blade.

Both Rumi and Jinu immediately straighten and bow. "Y es Celine, sorry Celine!"

Blood still boiling, Rumi's forced to drop her attempt at prying information from Jinu, instead resorting to sulky and pointed *looks* at him from across the cafe floor, to which he responds with a smirk and an occasional protruding tongue.

hV could they have been talking about?

Nerves humming with excitement, Rumi hits the save button, hits a second time to be sure, then throws her hands up in the air and whoops with excitement, Zoey and Mira immediately echoing with their own cheers.

A passing librarian pauses to glare through the window and all three girls cow a moment before sharing a look and giggling qietly .

"W e did it," Mira says breathlessly . "It' s *done*. And I think we *nailed* it."

"Oh, totally!" Zoey nods rapidly . "This is, like, the greatest project in the history of projects!"

"Thank you both for your hard work," Rumi of fers sincerely.

Zoey laughs. "Thank *you* for joining us! We couldnt have done this without you, seriously. Though I think Im going to miss our little study dates!"

Rumi's blood freezes.

Right.

They don't have a reason to meet up anymore.

No, wait, that's silly. They've specifically taken Rumi out to karaoke now, and the butler cafe. They're her *friends* Right?

…*Will* they still want to hang out after this?

Lost in her own head, Rumi nearly misses Mira quietly clearing her throat.

"Actually , Rumi, speaking of our study dates. Zoey and I have something we've been wanting to talk to you about."

Oh. Oh they really *aren't* interested in hanging out anymore.

Her heart sinks.

"We, well." Mira bites her lips, hesitating, and Rumi does her best to keep her panic from showing.

Let Mira finish .

"We were wondering," Zoey jumps in, "if you'd like to maybe, you know, change the study dates to a *different* kind of date? Tomorrow night, there's this lunar eclipse that's supposed to start just after it gets dark out, and Mira and I thought you might like to go to the park and, um, watch it together for a bit? With us?" There's an odd nervousness in her question that puzzles Rumi. Her cheeks flush beneath her freckles, and her fingers drum against the tabletop.

Going to the park with them sounds *wonderful* , and already Rumi feels ten times lighter at the thought that they *do* still want to hang out with her! She's never really had friends like them before, even if she occasionally flirts with and serves them aaaand she should probably come clean, actually, about the butler thing—

Ah.

Rumi slowly shakes her head. Her shift tomorrow night is all the way until the cafe closes, and there's no one else with her availability to cover for her, especially not this last minute. "Sorry ," she says, scrambling for an excuse, "but I've already got plans to study tomorrow night."

Mira's and Zoey's faces fall.

"That' s okay," murmurs Mira, beginning to busy herself with packing her study materials.

"I'm *really* sorry," Rumi begins.

Zoey interrupts her. "No, Rumi, it' s fine! Really! We understand, we promise! Would you still be okay doing things like karaoke with us again?"

Rumi blinks. "Of course! I'd love to!"

Mira's shoulders drop in what almost looks like relief. "Okay . Maybe next week? W e can still hang out like normal, right?"

That's all Rumi's wanted to hear. Her chest expands with joy, and she answers, "Absolutely! I'd love to!"

All the same, Mira and Zoey still look oddly crestfallen, and Rumi's excitement wavers.

No, she's reading too much into things.

Glancing at the clock, Zoey' s eyes widen. "Oh shoot, we need to get back! Well text you about our next hangout, okay?" She stares intently at Rumi, pleading.

"I look forward to it!"

Though she's still a little confused about Zoey's and Mira's weird reactions yesterday, Rumi feels light as a feather.

They want to keep hanging out with her!

Not that she *really* doubted it, of course, it's just that, well. Sure, the studying has gone well, and they've had their small hangouts outside of the library, but Rumi *also* hasn't even properly shown them her face apart from quick glimpses—heck, they don't even know her *hair color*.

Arriving like clockwork at their usual time, the sky already darkening outside with the early December nights of approaching winter, Rumi immediately notes that something is *very* off with Zoey and Mira. They smile warmly, but their smiles don't stretch as far, and their shoulders droop.

As Rumi seats them, Zoey slumps forward onto the table entirely. "I *need* like, the sweetest, most sugary dessert that possibly exists. Menu or not, *anything*."

Rumi thinks for a moment, quickly flipping through her memories of their various seasonal menus before landing on the perfect option. "Of course, my lady. Though not on our menu, may I recommend a Lancashire Courting Cake? It's a delightful vanilla cake with whipped cream, strawberries, and a healthy dusting of powdered sugar."

Zoey stretches her arms out and opens and closes her hands in a grabby motion. "Please yes, that one."

Mira leans her head all the way back so she's staring at the ceiling and groans. "Your specialty tea blend as well, please."

"Right away, my ladies." Rumi does her best to hide the crinkle in her brow as she darts to the kitchens and sets to work quickly throwing together the necessary vanilla cake mix in a miniature heart-shaped pan and tossing it in the oven. It'll be a while, but Mira and Zoey like to stay for a couple of hours at least anyway.

The chef, Bobby, gives her an odd look as she sets out strawberries, his knife pausing mid-slice through a set of sandwiches. "A little early for our Valentine's Day special, isn't it?" he asks.

"Special request. Something extra sweet."

Bobby nods slowly. "That'll do it. Anything else you need while you're back here?"

"Another order of cucumber sandwiches for table seven, please!" Rumi preps her signature tea blend, loads up a tray, and darts back out to the cafe proper, carefully setting it down upon Zoey and Mira's table.

As Rumi begins to pour the tea to serve, she asks, "Is everything okay, my ladies?"

Mira sighs heavily and runs her hand through her pink hair. "It's nothing we won't bounce back from. We're just a little sad, is all."

Rumi frowns.

Sad?

What happened?

Before she can open her mouth to ask, Zoey, face planted against the wood, says in a muffled voice, "We asked out a girl we both really like and she said no."

Stiffening, Rumi swallows and sets the tea cups in front of Mira and Zoey respectively, fighting a tremble in her hands.

They'd asked someone out?

And that person had the audacity to say *no*?

What—*how*?

Zoey and Mira are both so funny, and kind, and friendly, and and and —

[illegible]

"I'm sorry to hear that, my ladies."

Mira flaps her hand. "Thank you, Artemis, but we don't want to bother you with this. Really, we'll get over it. She still wants to be friends, so there's that."

"But you wanted something dif ferent?"

"Y eah," Zoey groans, still against the table. "W e only met this semester, but all three of us just *clicked* ! Mira and I have been talking about it for a while, and we don't technically know if she' s poly but we know she *is* queer , and we *thought* she maybe felt the same way? Or might be interested? *Argh* !" She suddenly sits upright with a noise of frustration, bangs mussed. "Like Mira said, it' s *f ine*, she can say no! It's just Artemis, she is *so* sweet and smart and talented, and she's still a little closed off, but like—*gggh* ." She drops her head back to the table with a thunk.

"W e really like her," Mira murmurs, bringing her tea cup to her lips and sipping, eyes shimmering sadly. "W e've never found someone *either* of us clicked like that with, let alone *both*. We're just a little sad, is all."

Fighting to tamp down the growing rage brewing within her at this mystery person who turned them down, Rumi says, "If there' s anything I can—"

"Artemis, you're wonderful, and we hope you enjoy us as customers as much as we enjoy you as our butler, but we don't want to push boundaries. We'll be fine."

Zoey whines, "Speak for yourself! Only this special cake Artemis promised will cure me!"

Mira chuckles, reaching forward to poke at the top of Zoey's head. "Alright, drama queen, up. With those kinds of theatrics, maybe *you* should look into being a butler."

Rolling herself back up to a sitting position, Zoey purses her lips thoughtfully. "I *would* look good in a butler suit, actually." Eyes twinkling, she adds, "And so would *you*, Mira." She turns to Rumi. "What do you think, Artemis? Are we butler material?"

Struck with the sudden image of Zoey and Mira in matching butler suits, something she has deliberately been trying to *not* consider, Rumi's mouth goes dry. "I-I think you'd both look great," she croaks, tugging at her collar. "Let me go check on the cake."

Rumi checks the cake's progress, then attends to a few other tables as Zoey and Mira speak quietly at their own. She stops by frequently and strains her ears to listen every time she passes, and she finds herself growing more and more furious as time drags on.

How could someone *reject* them?

Zoey and Mira are the loveliest, most talented, prettiest~~-she~~ shouldn't be thinking about that, probably, but it's also true, so whatever~~-fri~~ends and classmates and young women that Rumi's ever met. She's spent all semester looking forward to their study sessions, relaxing and having fun even as they work hard. They're always appreciative of her hard work, and respectful of her bizarre fashion choices and job caginess.

And someone *rejected* them?

It baffles Rumi, and makes her angry, and also tinges her thoughts green with envy, because~~-h~~, what's it matter if she *thinks* this—because *she'd* be *so* thrilled and honored to be asked out by them.

...Does Rumi have a crush on them?

Okay, wait, not the point right now.

Halfway through the shift, as Rumi's ready to go grab the cake, she catches Jinu stopping by Zoey's and Mira's table to say something. They greet him more warmly than they have in the past, and Rumi can't hear what they're saying, busy with a couple of elderly women with rather extensive questions about the tea choices, but when she looks up, she notices Jinu *frowning*, which isn't like him at all.

She has no time to ask, though. Rumi slips into the kitchen once more to put the finishing touches on the Lancashire Courting Cake, then brings it out to an immediately salivating Zoey (and *Mira*).

Serving the cake, she delicately slices it in half and sets one each on a porcelain plate, handing them to Zoey and Mira with some ornate accompanying silverware.

Zoey digs in immediately, moaning in glee. Even Mira hums her approval after she takes a bite, chewing thoughtfully.

"This is just what we needed to cheer ourselves up~~th~~ank you, Artemis! You're as lovely as always!" Zoey crows around a mouthful of cream and strawberries.

"Really," says Mira, "thank you. We appreciate you going out of your way to make us feel better today. You're as gracious a host as ever." She's earnest, watching Rumi intently until Rumi ducks her head in a small bow to accept the compliment.

Leaving them to the cake and grateful that she could at least stave off some of their heartbreak, Rumi returns to stewing on this mystery person who rejected them.

She runs on autopilot for a bit. Lost in thought, she serves customers with a serene smile, passes by the table to see Zoey and Mira finishing up their food, clears their plates, then finally notices Jinu slip into the back. She decides to follow after him~~th~~ere's a chance he has answers, and if he does, Rumi's going to do whatever she needs to wring them out of him.

He's in the changing room, taking a moment to check his hair and suit in the mirror. Nearly jumping as Rumi's eyes flash golden in the reflection, Jinu spins around mid-adjusting his bowtie. "Rumi," he states with concern? Disappointment? *What* is that tone?

"You know something," she accuses instantly, stepping inside.

"Uh, yeah, I do, and honestly, I don't get it?" He has an unexpectedly serious expression, brows knit and eyes narrowed. "I mean, I guess you shouldn't do anything you don't want to, but *really*? I've seen how happy they make you!"

"Very happy, yes!" Rumi clenches her jaw. "Which is exactly why I'm so mad and want to know details."

Jinu stares. "You're *what*? Did they do something seriously wrong? Because it looks to me like they're just pretty heartbroken about the whole thing, and politely, given how respectful they act here, I really can't imagine them pushing you to *anger*."

"Wha—no, I'm not angry at *them*!" Rumi sputters. "I'm angry at whoever rejected them, and I want to know who!"

Silence settles for a moment, still and uncertain.

Then, Jinu stumbles backwards against the wall, dropping his head to his hands. His shoulders shake and Rumi watches him, concerned. "Are you okay?" she asks hesitantly.

Is he *crying*?

Rumi wasn't *that* harsh, was she? That was barely anything! Is he seriously upset by—

Finally, she registers the noises he's making.

He's *laughing*.

Rumi lunges forward and snatches his hands away from his face to see that he's already in near tears, his mouth twisted in a contorted grimace and cheeks puffed and turning red as he fights to keep it in.

"What the *hell*?"

At that, Jinu loses it. He bursts out into raucous laughter, literal tears streaming from his eyes as he slaps his knees and doubles over.

"Jinu. What is happening right now? Why are— *Jinu* answer me I swear"—

"You're an *idiot*," he gasps, wrapping his arms around his stomach and giggling uncontrollably.

Rumi's jaw drops and she makes a noise of sheer offense. "Excuse me!?"

"You," Jinu points at her, "are an *idiot*."

"Would you just tell me what's going on?" Her tone is demanding and sharp, and her annoyance is spiking with every passing second. He has information and instead of *sharing* it, he's *laughing* at her and calling her an *idiot*?

It takes another solid minute for Jinu to properly catch his breath between wheezes, but *finally* he stops giggling long enough to look Rumi in the eyes. "Someone rejected them, correct?"

Tilting her head and rolling her eyes, Rumi says, "Yes, I already know this."

"They asked this person on a date to go see the lunar eclipse tonight, and she politely turned them down by saying she was busy *studying* when classes for the semester are *over*."

Rumi frowns, the gears of her mind turning.

Jinu meets her eyes almost helplessly. "Does that sound at all familiar to *you*, Rumi?"

Does that sound—

Rumi freezes.

Wait.

Wait wait wait.

*Wait wait wait

Head in her hands, Rumi begins to breathe unsteadily. "They left. They left, and they don't know, and they think I rejected them, and I need to fix this, but I can't—"

A firm and familiar grip squeezes Rumi's shoulder. She jerks, suddenly confronted with Celine, dressed in her own pressed butler suit and scrutinizing Rumi with an unreadable expression.

"Sorry, Celine, I'll get back to work, I—"

Celine's white gloved finger comes to rest gently on Rumi's lips in a quiet command to stop talking. "I'll take your tables," she says primly. "We're not too busy tonight."

Rumi gapes at her.

Raising an eyebrow, Celine gestures to the door.

"Go."

Swallowing, Rumi nods her head rapidly, gives Celine a big hug, gives Jihu a hug, then scrambles out of the store with zero regard to her appearance and what she's wearing, only one thought on her mind:

Find Zoey and Mira.

The night air is crisp, cool enough to keep Rumi comfortable as she darts down the streets of Seoul. Her dress shoes clack against the concrete sidewalks as she hurriedly slips around the usual hustle and bustle of a Seoul evening, ignoring the number of odd glances shot her way.

She's not far from campus, or the park, and she hopes frantically that her guess is right, that Zoey and Mira decided to go watch anyway, even without her there.

A lunar eclipse.

Because Rumi's mentioned how much she likes the moon.

Breathing heavily, Rumi stays at a steady jog, not even bothering to glance at the sky to see the eclipse for herself, too focused on her mission at hand.

Find Zoey and Mira.

Find Zoey and Mira.

Find—

She skids to a halt as she enters the park and~~th~~ere! At an empty picnic table, Zoey's sprawled along the bench and staring at the few stars visible in the city night sky while Mira sketches idly in the margins of a notebook. Neither notice Rumi as she approaches until she steps off the path and the crunch of dead leaves underfoot signals her arrival.

Mira's the one who looks over first, immediately fumbling to stand. "*Aein's?* "she asks, baf fled. At that, Zoey jolts upright and stares as well.

Ugh, Rumi has to look an absolute *mess* . She's been speeding through the streets of Seoul, desperate to reach this isolated park; her hair is windblown and tangled, strands drooping against her cheeks, and she feels a small and uncomfortable layer of sweat beneath her jacket.

"Whaaat are you doing here?" Zoey drags the first word out, swinging her legs over the edge of the bench and standing up as well. "Did you~~ar~~ent you at work?"

"No!" Rumi blurts out. "W ell, yes, but no, someone is covering for me ~~tha~~t' s not important. Look, I came because I need to talk to you both. About what you were mentioning earlier."

A little warily, Mira takes a step forward. "Respectfully , Artemis, this doesn't seem very professional. I apologize if we've maybe given you the wrong impression? We *do* like you a lot, but also, we understand you're playing a character , I promise—"

"No, that's not—well, again, yes, that's *true* , I'm playing a character , but I came because of the rejection, I wanted to—you said you liked someone, and they said no, but actually—" Rumi trips over each word, struggling to convey everything she needs to as fast as she wants to. Her Artemis persona has completely evaporated, leaving nothing but her standard, stumbling self.

"Oh, um. You weren't the person who rejected us, if that wasn't clear," Zoey says slowly , tone gentle. "Don't get us wrong, you're like, *really* hot, but we don't actually *know* you, so like—"

Rumi raises her hands, holding them palm out in a gesture of openness. "But you *do*!"

Mira's eyebrow raises to her hairline. "Uh, respectfully , we really don't, and this is starting to cross into a territory I'm not sure I'm okay with."

Scrabbling for the right words, Rumi shakes her head. "No, I mean, you *do* know me! But not as Artemis!"

Zoey scrunches her face, squinting. "Then who?"

"As *Rumi*!"

The words dissipate into the quiet of the empty surroundings, vanishing into the maples and the dirt beneath their feet.

"Y... our eyes are *golden*," remarks Zoey .

"Contacts!" Rumi points at them. "They're contacts! *I'm* Rumi! And I like you back!"

Arms crossed over her chest, Mira seems unenthused. "You're Rumi. And have been this whole time. All semester."

Blushing darkly, Rumi bites her lip. "Yes. I was—I was embarrassed, but I *really* like you two, and"—

"It's a little hard to believe," Zoey notes, cutting in, then sheepishly ducking her head in apology. "Sorry to interrupt, but like, Artemis, this is a little weird? No offense, but Rumi's our friend and crush, and"—

"Tardigrades! There are thousands of tardigrades stuck on the moon!"

Zoey's and Mira's jaws drop.

"And I know that because I *love* the moon, and you asked me out yesterday to watch the lunar eclipse with you both but I said no and lied about studying because I had to work a shift as Artemis tonight, but also I *swear* I didn't realize you were asking me out, I thought it was just a friend thing, and"—

"Oh my god," Zoey murmurs. "It *is* you."

Mira blurts, "Is this why you never took off that fucking hoodie?"

"Yes, sorry, it is, but anyway, my point is that my answer *isn't* a no, it's a *yes*." Rumi's rambling finally halts and she takes a deep breath, heart pounding rapidly in her chest.

Zoey steps forward, eyes alight. "You're Rumi," she says deliberately, taking another step. Rumi nods. "Rumi is Artemis." Another nod, another step. "And your actual answer to us asking you out isn't a *no*, it's a *yes.*" Another nod and step until Zoey's right in front of Rumi, serious and focused.

Suddenly, her face splits into a wide grin and she laughs, high-pitched peals that sparkle like the stars. "Holy *shit*, that's—you're

Rumi! And you like us back?

Rumi keeps nodding. "I do, I really do," she says, throat closing up a little with overwhelming emotion. "I don't think I realized how much until tonight, but I've wished for a connection like what I have with you two since I was a kid, and I was so worried that you wouldn't even care enough to still be *friends* with me that I never even *considered* any other options!" A couple of tears prick at the corners of her eyes.

With a few quick strides, Mira flanks Zoey, staring intently at Rumi. "You weren't even sure we still wanted to be *friends*?" she asks in disbelief.

Shrugging helplessly, Rumi says, "Yeah. I just—"

"Can I prove it to you?" Mira leans in so close that her nose is nearly brushing Rumi's. "Can I prove to you how much I like you?"

Her breath ghosts across Rumi's cheeks. Rumi nods for perhaps the millionth time that evening, eyes wide.

Mira angles her head down and slowly presses her lips to Rumi's. She's soft, and warm, and Rumi closes her eyes and sinks into the touch.

Then, Mira's pulling away, and suddenly Zoey's in front of her. "Can I prove it too?" she whispers teasingly.

Rumi gulps audibly and leans forward; Zoey meets her halfway, and where Mira's kiss was soft and chaste, Zoey's is bright and energetic. She moves her mouth against Rumi's, playfully slotting their lips together before breaking the kiss after a few seconds.

Blinking, Rumi stares at them, stunned, before her cheeks stretch and her eyes crinkle as she smiles. A mischievous thought springs to her mind, and before she can stop herself, Rumi bows properly and says, "Thank you, my ladies."

Zoey shrieks with laughter as Mira groans and comments, "You know, I thought you reminded me of someone with your mask off."

Standing back upright from her bow, Rumi finally looks beyond Mira and Zoey to the tree and then the sky above.

The lunar eclipse is beautiful, a full moon of russet red fading to umber and orange nestled amidst a blanket of black;its light illuminates Zoey and Mira in faded hues as the rattling shadows of branches stripe across their faces.

"Beautiful," Rumi murmurs, unable to help herself.

Her gaze is fixed entirely on Zoey and Mira.

Huddled together in her *girlfriends'* dorm room during the last day of the semester, the three of them cluster around Zoey's laptop, staring with bated breath. Rumi, no longer hiding around them, has her hood down, her hair done up in a long braid, and no face mask in sight.

Zoey hesitantly clicks the refresh button.

The final grade for their project appears.

All three of them cheer.

Double-checking her golden contact lenses in the mirror, Rumi fluffs out her hair, then turns to tug on a presented pair of white gloves shoved in front of her. Laughing, Rumi checks them over before stepping aside so Zoey can scrutinize her own appearance in the mirror.

She squints, straightens her teal tie, then grins widely, spinning so she can observe herself from as many angles as she can within the mirror.

A low whistle sounds from the doorway, and Rumi looks up from intensely studying just how good one of her girlfriends looks in a suit to see her other girlfriend leaning against the door frame, her hair tied back in a lengthy ponytail with a pink ribbon and a suit hugging her body perfectly.

"You look *good*," Mira comments appreciatively, raking her eyes over both of them. "Never thought I'd see you in a suit, Zoey, but I could get used to this. And *you*," she turns to Rumi, "already know how good you look, but just in case you need the reminder: you and Zoey are *gorgeous*." She winks and adds, purring, "My beautiful girlfriends."

Giggling, Zoey flounces over to give Mira a quick peck and return the compliment before doing the same to Rumi, who responds with what might be the world's dopiest smile.

Passing by the door, Jinu pokes his head in and laughs. When Rumi glares in response, he gives her an exaggerated thumbs-up, then runs off, cackling.

"I still can't believe you got us a seasonal gig here!" Zoey says.

"I still can't believe you *talked us into* getting a seasonal gig here," Mira snarks.

Rumi protests, "You're the ones who asked *me*!"

Shrugging, Mira comments, "Figured it was only fair to get to know our partner from the other end of things. Plus, again, we look *good*."

"You sure do," Rumi slips out, blushing fiercely as Mira and Zoey burst out laughing.

"Almost time, girls!" Celine's voice calls from down the hall. "We're opening in five minutes! Rumi, are they ready?"

"They're ready!" calls Rumi, taking their suit-clad appearances in one more time with blatant affection and want. "Alright," she says, turning to Zoey and Mira and ushering them out of the back and into the cafe, "let's see how this new group project of ours turns out, shall we?"

Despite the cold bite of winter outside, the cafe comes alive with warmth and hospitality and smiles amongst guests and workers alike, enjoying a silly spot of fun in a lively, self-made corner of Seoul.

Outside, as always, the moon watches.

End Notes

And that's a wrap!!

A surprisingly more difficult piece for me to write - I don't normally do college *or* cafe aus, but this one was SUCH a fun concept, I couldn't help but be drawn to it instantly! It was also just a great chance for me to practice some more fluff and comedy, and I hope it all came together!

Once again, massive shoutout to Whimsy and her incredible idea and art, which is the reason for this whole fic in the first place! <3

Feel free to come yell at me on tumblr under arendellesfirstwinter or on twitter under arendelles1stw, and I hope you all enjoyed!

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!